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California lawmakers call UC, CSU response to antisemitic incidents 'woefully inadequate'

November 8, 2023 | Sacramento Bee, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)
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OpenURL Link

Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

CALIFORNIA LEGISLATIVE JEWISH CAUCUS PENS LETTER TO UC, CSU LEADERS

It has been a month since the militant group Hamas attacked Israel, killing more than 1,000 people, kidnapping hundreds more and provoking a massive counter-attack that has led to thousands of Palestinian deaths in Gaza.

In that time, both the University of California and California State University systems have seen an increase in antisemitic incidents — including physical abuse, intimidation, hate speech and online harassment.

The wave of incidents has prompted the California Legislative Jewish Caucus to send a letter to UC President Michael Drake and CSU Chancellor Mildred Garcia demanding that they take action to address the crisis.

"Sadly, there is a widespread feeling among Jewish students — as well as within the broader Jewish community — that many campus administrators do not understand the severity of the crisis and have been unwilling to take appropriate action to meet this moment. This is unacceptable and must change immediately," the letter reads in part.

While the caucus, which is co-chaired by Sen. Scott Wiener and Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, wrote that they support "robust protections" for freedom of speech for those opposing the Israeli government or U.S. foreign policy, "what our community has endured in recent weeks — which has included physical assaults, vandalism, and calls for violence and genocide against Jews — is beyond the pale."

Caucus members called the response by campus administrators so far "woefully inadequate."

"What is deeply distressing to many in the Jewish community — including members of our Jewish Caucus — is the pervasive feeling that the response by campus officials to the current situation would be markedly different if it involved another historically marginalized group. We cannot imagine — nor would we tolerate — silence or equivocation if any other group on campus were being similarly targeted," the letter reads.

The letter demands that the UC and CSU systems take immediate action to protect Jewish students, and to enact a zero-tolerance policy toward antisemitism on-campus.

They also call on university leaders to develop "comprehensive, systemwide plans" to address antisemitism and ensure that Jews feel safe and welcome.

CALIFORNIA REPUBLICANS VOTE AGAINST TLAIB CENSURE

Via David Lightman...

California Republican Reps. Tom McClintock and John Duarte were among four Republicans who voted late Tuesday not to censure Rep. Rashida Tlaib because of her sharp criticisms of Israel.

Tlaib, D-Michigan, the only Palestinian-American member of Congress, has been outspoken against Israel's treatment of the Palestinian people and the invasion of Gaza. She was censured in a bipartisan 234 to 188 vote, as 22 Democrats, including Rep. Jim Costa, D-Fresno, joined 212 Republicans to protest Tlaib's views on Israel.

Last week, she posted a video on X, formerly Twitter, that included people chanting “from the river to the sea.” That phrase is considered code for eliminating Israel, according to the Anti-Defamation League.

The six Republicans joined 202 Democrats in an unsuccessful effort to end the bid to censure Tlaib. A vote on censure, which carries no penalties, is expected Wednesday.

The Californians’ concern was that free speech is being stifled.

“Censure is to punish corrupt deeds or egregious breaches of decorum. It should never be used to stifle political speech, no matter how offensive and outrageous,” McClintock, R-Elk Grove, tweeted Tuesday. “Voters alone are entitled to hold members accountable for their opinions, words and votes.”

He wrote Monday on his website that “both parties have a lunatic fringe we must control. But we cannot control it by force. Only by reason.”

Duarte, R-Modesto, had similar thoughts. When efforts to censure Tlaib began last week, he said in a statement, “What is being expressed by Representative Tlaib and others concerning Hamas’s terrorism has been appalling, infuriating, and disgusting. I vehemently disagree with her ignorant statements about the war in Israel.”

But, he said, “she still has a First Amendment right to free speech to voice these views, however ridiculous they may be.”

Remember, he said, “In this case, the First Amendment acts as a spotlight for us to identify hatred and condemn it swiftly. Censure is a tool that the House must use with caution. I fear this may be weaponized in the future to silence those who have divergent views.”

SHOULD WORKERS GET ‘SMOKE DAYS’ OFF?

In California, living and working in smoke has become a sad fact of life. Each year, the state is scorched by massive wildfires, sending up toxic plumes that cause and aggravate serious health conditions.

California Rep. Barbara Lee, D-Oakland, has introduced a bill that would require employers to grant up to 12 weeks of unpaid leave per year to employees stricken by smoke inhalation.

The Smoke Mitigation and Occupational Key Enhancements Act, or SMOKE Act, requires employers to monitor the Air Quality Index for adverse conditions due to smoke and inform employees of such conditions. It also requires employers to maintain personal protective equipment, PPE, and engineering and administrative controls (such as enclosed structures with filtered air).

In a statement, Lee said that climate change has made wildfires a part of daily life in California, particularly in the Bay Area.

“In the same way the northeast deals with blizzards, the Midwest deals with tornadoes, and the southeast deals with hurricanes – we need to retrofit our economy to adapt to the growing climate crisis,” Lee said in a statement.

The bill is co-sponsored by fellow California Democratic Rep. Mark DeSaulnier, as well as Rep. Raúl Grijalva, D-Arizona, and Rep. Jasmine Crockett, D-Texas.

“We need to strengthen labor protections to address poor air quality and provide workers with the necessary equipment to guarantee their safety during times of risk,” Grijalva said in a statement.

The bill is supported by a number of groups, including the Sierra Club, the American Lung Association and the Union of Concerned Scientists.

“A federal smoke protection standard would be a tremendous step forward in addressing this mounting crisis, as research shows that unhealthy air from wildfire smoke can cause numerous health problems, with people of color and people with low incomes disproportionately exposed,” said Kristina Dahl of the Union of Concerned Scientists.

CALIFORNIA SEES SLIGHT UPTICK IN VOTER REGISTRATION

California has seen a 2-percentage point increase in voter registration from this time four years ago, according to a new report from the California Secretary of State’s Office.

As of Oct. 3, 82% of California adults are registered to vote, up from 80% in 2019.

Out of those 22 million registered voters, 46% are registered Democrats, a nearly 3% increase from 2019. Another 23% are registered Republicans, which marks little change from 2019, and 22% are no party preference, a 4.5% decrease.

No other party tops 1 million members.

In Sacramento County, out of 1.1 million eligible adults, 876,204 are registered to vote, with 45% Democrats, 24% Republicans and 21% no party preference.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

“A night out should never be interrupted by gunfire, but we’ve witnessed this scene too many times since, including in Lewiston, Maine, just a few weeks ago. California has taken many steps to stop gun violence, but this must be a nationwide effort.”

- Former Rep. Gabby Giffords, in a statement observing the fifth anniversary of the mass shooting at a restaurant in Thousand Oaks.

Best of The Bee:

Gov. Gavin Newsom’s approval rating among California voters has sunk to its lowest level on record, with nearly half disapproving of his performance, according to a new poll from the Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies, via Maggie Angst.If you live, work or learn on a California State University campus, don’t expect anyone to respond to your maintenance requests next Tuesday. The 1,100 skilled tradespeople represented by Teamsters Local 2010 — which include electricians, plumbers, mechanics and locksmiths among others — will walk off the job from midnight on Nov. 14 to midnight on Nov. 15. The strike will effectively halt all maintenance and work orders across 22 of the CSU’s 23 campuses, via Maya Miller.Last year, Californians voted to ban flavored tobacco products from being sold in the state. But a new study found that Californians appear to be skirting the ban by shopping online, via Andrew Sheeler.When Sacramento residents learned they’d be required to recycle their food waste as part of the state’s overarching mission to fight climate change, many had questions about how to integrate the new law into their everyday lives. Sacramento’s organic waste program is just over a year old and still, there’s confusion about what food scrap goes in which bin, via Brianna Taylor.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Sheeler, A. (2023, November 8). California lawmakers call UC, CSU response to antisemitic incidents ‘woefully inadequate’. *Sacramento Bee, The: Web Edition Articles (CA).* Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1952E1B50B1B6628.